“We Already Know What Dad Likes”

Three mistakes families make about a parent's preferences, and the habit that replaces each.

Every family is sure it knows how Dad likes things. Some of those facts are older than anyone realizes, and that's nobody's fault. Families tend to slip in the same three ways here, and each one trades in for a question.

1 Assuming the family already knows the details

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Ask three relatives how Dad likes his eggs and you get three answers, each given with complete confidence. Your sister is sure he can't stand fish. Your brother has watched him order it every Friday for years.

WHY IT HAPPENS You've known him all your life, so it doesn't feel like guessing. But each of you knows a different stretch of his days, and habits change without anyone announcing it.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write down what you believe, then ask him, and mark each line confirmed, corrected or not yet asked. Where he corrects you, his version goes on the page. AARP's planning guide for families puts it simply: try not to anticipate what your loved one might say, and listen. [1]

2 Waiting for a transition before asking personal questions

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “We'll ask when we need to.” The questions about how he likes his mornings get saved for some future day when there's a reason to ask them.

WHY IT HAPPENS Asking can feel like announcing that something is wrong, and nothing is. AARP's guide says these conversations are easy to put off, because it never seems like the right time to bring up what we expect will be an uncomfortable topic. It also says you may be surprised to find your loved one has been meaning to have the talk too. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask one thing this week, over something ordinary: a meal, a drive, the Sunday phone call. The Conversation Project's workbook says to take it in small pieces, and that it's always okay to skip a question. A calm week is when Dad has time to tell the story behind the answer. [2]

3 Treating old preferences as permanently fixed

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The page gets written once and filed. Or it never gets written, because “Dad's always been an early riser” has been true since you were in school and nobody has checked since.

WHY IT HAPPENS A fact about a parent feels permanent, and so does anything written down. But the Conversation Project's workbook notes that people's preferences often change as their health changes or as time goes by. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Put “as of” and a date on the page. Agree with Dad on when you'll go over it together again, and treat today's answers as today's. The workbook's own suggestion is to revisit it over time and see whether the answers have changed. [2]

The one habit behind all three

Ask him, write down what he says in his own words, and put a date on it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't tell you what Dad prefers or what he'd want in a situation he hasn't talked about. It names three habits of thinking, which are the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to trade for a question. The care interview asks its questions in order, across Dad's whole situation and not only his preferences, keeps his account apart from the family's, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The remarks about putting the conversation off, not anticipating his answers, taking it in small pieces and preferences changing over time come from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care